RAF PILOT'S UNIFORM

RAF fighter pilots generally wore as much as they could in flight because of fear of fire. If the fuel tank in front of the cockpit was hit and erupted into flames, a pilot could be disfigured for life in the seconds it took to slide back the canopy and exit the aircraft. Hence it was desirable to cover every centimetre of the body, with more than one layer if possible. On the other hand, when they had to "scramble" at short notice, pilots often flew in unlikely garb, for example with a jacket thrown over pyjamas.

Peaked cap
This privately tailored peaked cap was part of an officer's service dress. It was usually worn to the aircraft and then put aside while the helmet and mask were worn. The brass and gold cord badge was unique to officers.

Officer-rank lace on epaulettes

Whistle needed if pilot was ditched at sea

Officer's badge

Battledress blouse and trousers
Introduced in 1940, this battledress was made of wool serge and partially lined with cotton drill. According to regulation, it was never worn when the pilot was off duty.

Pilot's brevet (badge)

Distinguished Flying Cross ribbon

Extra long gloves to cover wrists

D-type gauntlets
Introduced in 1942, these flying gauntlets could be worn with silk inner gloves and/or electrically heated insets. They were deliberately long to protect the wrists and hands in the event of a fire.



Fastening oxygen mask and microphone to flying helmet



Three-buttoned life vest on top of battledress